

RTL Design Sherpa

Delta Hardware Architecture Specification 1.0

October 16, 2026

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1 Delta Has Index

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2 Document Information

2.1 Delta Hardware Architecture Specification

Document Properties

Property	Value
Document Title	Delta Hardware Architecture Specification
Version	1.0
Date	2026-10-12
Status	Released
Classification	Open Source - MIT License

2.2 Revision History

Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Description
1.0	2026-10-12	RTL Design Sherpa	Initial HAS/MAS split; documents the 2026-10-12 richness options (TSTRB and AMBA5 TWAKEUP/TPARITY) and flat-only topology.
1.1	2026-10-12	RTL Design Sherpa	AMBA 5 interface parity per IHI 0051B ch. 5 (issue #102): `TPARITY`/`PW_WIDTH`/`--parity-width` replaced by the odd-parity check signals `TDATACHK` … `TWAKEUPCHK` (spec widths, checked at every port, sticky `*_parity_error`), matching `rtl/amba/axis5`. First `dv/` suite.

2.3 Document Purpose

This Hardware Architecture Specification (HAS) is the high-level view of the Delta AXI4-Stream crossbar generator — the map you read before you integrate, not the schematic. It covers:

- System-level architecture and data flow
- AXI4-Stream protocol support (base and rich flavors)
- Interface definitions and requirements
- Performance characteristics
- Integration guidelines

For micro-architecture, FSM designs, and signal-level detail, see the companion **Delta Micro-Architecture Specification (MAS)**.

2.4 Intended Audience

- System architects defining streaming interconnect topology
- Hardware engineers integrating Delta into SoC designs
- Verification engineers planning test strategies
- Technical managers evaluating Delta capabilities

2.5 Related Documents

- **Delta MAS** - Micro-Architecture Specification (detailed block-level)
- **PRD.md** - Product requirements and overview
- **CLAUDE.md** - AI assistant integration guide
- **QUICK_START.md** - Hands-on generator guide

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3 Purpose and Scope

3.1 What is Delta?

Delta is a Python-based AXI4-Stream crossbar generator. You provide the number of masters, the number of slaves, the data width, and a few optional sideband knobs; it hands you back parameterized, synthesizable SystemVerilog. The name follows the water theme used elsewhere in RTL Design Sherpa (like RAPIDS): a river delta is where one channel splits into many branches, analogous to crossbar routing.

3.2 The Problem Delta Solves

A hand-written AXI4-Stream crossbar is error-prone. Building one means writing per-slave arbitration, packet-atomic grant logic, data multiplexing for TDATA/TVALID/TLAST/TDEST/TID/TUSER, and TREADY backpressure steering — then doing it again every time the master or slave count changes.

Delta automates all of it:

- Define the crossbar in a single command line
- Run `bin/delta_generator.py`
- Get production-ready SystemVerilog RTL

3.3 Scope

This specification covers:

- High-level architecture and block organization
- AXI4-Stream protocol support, including the optional base + rich signal sets
- Interface requirements and signal conventions
- Performance characteristics and resource estimates
- Integration guidelines and verification status

3.4 Out of Scope

These live in the companion MAS or are deliberate non-goals:

- Detailed FSM state diagrams and transitions (MAS)
- Signal-level timing diagrams (MAS)
- Internal pipeline structures (MAS)
- AXI4/AXI4-Lite/APB protocol conversion (deliberate non-goal; see Bridge or APB crossbar siblings)
- Dynamic reconfiguration or advanced routing algorithms

3.5 Non-Goal: Memory-Mapped Protocol Conversion

Delta is **AXI4-Stream only**. It does not convert to or from AXI4, AXI4-Lite, or APB. If you need address-mapped fabrics, use the sibling `bridge` or `lattice-apbx-xbar` components.

4 Document Conventions

4.1 Naming Conventions

Naming Conventions

Convention	Meaning	Example
`s_axis_*`	Signals on the master side of the crossbar (inputs)	`s_axis_tdata[m]`
`m_axis_*`	Signals on the slave side of the crossbar (outputs)	`m_axis_tready[s]`
`[NUM_MASTERS]`	Unpacked array dimension, one entry per master	`s_axis_tvalid [NUM_MASTERS]`
`[NUM_SLAVES]`	Unpacked array dimension, one entry per slave	`m_axis_tvalid [NUM_SLAVES]`
`m`	Master index	`for (int m = 0; m < NUM_MASTERS; m++)`
`s`	Slave index	`for (int s = 0; s < NUM_SLAVES; s++)`

4.2 Signal Direction Conventions

All directions are stated from the crossbar's point of view:

- `s_axis_*` signals are driven by upstream masters and received by Delta.
- `m_axis_*` signals are driven by Delta and received by downstream slaves.
- `aclk` and `aresetn` are driven by the system.

4.3 Numbering Conventions

- Masters are numbered `0` to `NUM_MASTERS-1`.
- Slaves are numbered `0` to `NUM_SLAVES-1`.
- `TDEST` is interpreted as a slave index; legal values are `0` to `NUM_SLAVES-1`.

4.4 Typographic Conventions

- `code font` is used for signal names, parameters, and file paths.
- **Bold** is used for emphasis and defined terms.
- Tables use the RTL Design Sherpa corporate document style.

4.5 Versioning Conventions

This document uses semantic-style major.minor revision numbers. The initial release is 1.0.

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5 Definitions and Acronyms

5.1 Acronyms

Acronyms and Definitions

Acronym	Definition
AXIS	AXI4-Stream (ARM AMBA streaming protocol)
AMBA5	ARM AMBA 5 protocol extensions, including TWAKEUP and the T*CHK interface check signals
TDEST	Transaction destination (slave ID in AXI4-Stream)
TID	Transaction ID (master identifier in AXI4-Stream)
TUSER	User-defined sideband in AXI4-Stream
TSTRB	Byte strobe / byte qualifier in AXI4-Stream
TWAKEUP	AMBA 5 wakeup hint signal
T*CHK	AXI5-Stream interface check signals (`TDATACHK`, `TVALIDCHK`, …), odd parity, IHI 0051B chapter 5
RR	Round-robin arbitration
LUT	Look-up table (FPGA logic resource)
FF	Flip-flop (FPGA register resource)

5.2 Key Terms

Base flavor
The default generated crossbar with the seven-signal set: `tdata`, `tvalid`, `tready`, `tlast`, `tdest`, `tid`, `tuser`.

Rich flavor
A generated crossbar with optional additional signals enabled: `tstrb` and/or AMBA 5 `twakeup` with the `t*chk` check signals.

Packet atomicity
The property that once a master is granted access to a slave, it retains that grant until the current packet's `TLAST` beat has been transferred. No other master may interleave beats on that slave during the packet.

Request matrix
A per-slave collection of master request bits. `request_matrix[s][m]` is true when master `m` has a valid transaction targeting slave `s`.

Grant matrix
A per-slave one-hot (or zero-hot) collection of master grant bits. `grant_matrix[s][m]` is true when master `m` currently owns slave `s`.

TDEST decode
The combinational translation of `s_axis_tdest[m]` into a slave index in the request matrix. Delta does not use an address map.

TWAKEUP steering
The AMBA 5 sideband path that forwards a master's `s_axis_twakeup` hint to the slave selected by `s_axis_tdest`. It is an OR-per-slave and may assert before `TVALID`.

6 Use Cases

6.1 Primary: RISC Cores + DSP Array

Scenario: Four small RISC-V cores route compute tasks to sixteen DSP accelerators.

Configuration:

- 4 masters (RISC cores)
- 16 slaves (DSP arrays)
- 64-bit data width
- Flat topology

Benefits:

- Each RISC core can target any DSP (full flexibility).
- Per-slave round-robin arbitration prevents starvation.
- Two-cycle latency keeps task dispatch responsive.
- All sixteen DSPs can operate concurrently when traffic targets different slaves.

6.2 Secondary: Sensor/Peripheral Fabric

Scenario: Multiple sensor streams feed a smaller set of processing blocks.

Configuration:

- 2-8 masters (sensor front-ends)
- 2-4 slaves (aggregation or filter blocks)
- 32-bit data width with optional `TSTRB` byte qualifiers

Benefits:

- Direct TDEST routing removes the need for an address decoder.
- Packet atomicity preserves frame boundaries from each sensor.
- Optional `TSTRB` supports sparse byte-valid data from byte-packed sensors.

6.3 Tertiary: AMBA 5-Aware Streaming Interconnect

Scenario: A low-power subsystem needs wakeup hints and AXI5-Stream interface parity protection.

Configuration:

- Masters and slaves that implement AMBA 5 AXI-Stream
- `--amba5` enabled

Benefits:

- `TWAKEUP` lets a master wake a target slave before presenting data.
- The IHI 0051B chapter 5 check signals (`TDATACHK` and the rest, odd parity) are carried across the fabric and checked at each crossbar port. A sticky per-port flag reports a fault.
- Generated ports port-match the `rtl/amba/axis5/*` interface conventions.

6.4 Educational Demonstration

Scenario: Teach interconnect design trade-offs and code generation.

Configuration:

- Generate flat crossbars of varying sizes into `rtl_test/`.
- Compare latency, throughput, and resource estimates from `delta_performance_model.py`.

Benefits:

- Hands-on learning with working RTL.
- Clear performance comparisons.
- Demonstrates specification-driven design and Python-based RTL generation.

6.5 Mesh-Mode: Monitored Manycore Fabric

Scenario: A 3-D manycore fabric of SERV cores and CGRA compute cells exchanges stream traffic while ocelus observers collect statistics and rapids DMA feeds the boundary.

Configuration:

- `--topology mesh` with fabric dimensions `cells-x`, `cells-y`, `cells-z`.
- One `delta_mesh_cell` at every fabric coordinate; rapids attaches at boundary cells' local ports.
- ocelus observers tap cell ports for flit/packet/stall/latency counters.
- Cell contents (SERV, CGRA, ocelus) are out of scope — delta sees only the AXI4-Stream at the local port.

  IMPLEMENTED — Mesh mode RTL is generated by `delta_generator.py --topology mesh`. The design described here is per the owner-approved delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`). The flat crossbar remains the implemented default.

  Still deferred: CXS migration, MonBus observation aggregation in the tile IP, 1 cycle/hop lookahead (issue #120), and SRAM FIFO_IMPL (issue #118).

Benefits:

- Table-routed 3-D mesh scales without the all-to-all wiring of a flat crossbar.
- Per-cell routing tables and broadcast mode-switches let the same physical fabric run different communication patterns.
- Built-in observability gives software-visible performance data from the fabric.

7 Key Features

7.1 Flat M×N Crossbar

Delta generates a single self-contained SystemVerilog module implementing a full M×N crossbar. Every master can reach every slave; each slave has its own round-robin arbiter.

7.2 TDEST-Based Routing

There is no address map. The target slave is taken directly from `s_axis_tdest`. This makes request decode simpler than an address-based crossbar and removes configuration risk.

7.3 Packet-Atomic Round-Robin Arbitration

Each slave arbiter grants one master at a time and holds that grant until the current packet's TLAST beat is accepted. This guarantees:

- No packet interleaving on a slave.
- Fair bandwidth allocation among contending masters.
- Streaming packet boundaries are preserved end-to-end.

7.4 Combinational Data Mux with Registered Grant

The data path from the granted master to the selected slave is combinational. The grant decision is registered on `aclk`, giving a predictable two-cycle latency while keeping the critical path short.

7.5 Optional Richness (Default Off)

Two command-line options add sidebands without changing the default output:

- `--strb-width N` adds TSTRB byte qualifiers (port-matches `rtl/amba/axis4`).
- `--amba5` adds TWAKEUP and the IHI 0051B chapter 5 odd-parity check signals (TDATACHK ... TWAKEUPCHK), with sticky per-port error flags. The ports match `rtl/amba/axis5`.

When neither option is used, the generated module is byte-identical to pre-2026-10-12 output.

7.6 Optional Packet Counters

Per-master and per-slave 32-bit packet counters count completed packets (`TVALID && TREADY && TLAST`). Disable them with `--no-counters` to save area.

7.7 Formal Assertions

When `FORMAL` is defined, the generated RTL includes assertions that check:

- One-hot (or zero-hot) grants per slave.
- `TDEST` is within range when `s_axis_tvalid` is asserted.

7.8 Code Generation

The generator is a Python script (`bin/delta_generator.py`) that reuses the unified `Module` framework. It produces lint-clean SystemVerilog and is the single source of truth for all checked-in RTL variants.

7.9 Mesh-Mode Features

IMPLEMENTED — Mesh mode is a generator option that emits `delta_mesh_cell` and a fabric top. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`). The flat TDEST crossbar remains the default and is untouched.

Still deferred: CXS migration (owner plan, parallel rapids_cxs work), MonBus observation aggregation in the tile IP (parallel session), 1 cycle/hop lookahead (issue #120), and SRAM FIFO_IMPL (issue #118).

- **3-D table-routed mesh of identical cells** — one `delta_mesh_cell` per fabric coordinate, connected to ±X/±Y/±Z neighbors, the two diagonal-axis links (P_DIA for tetrad-scale, P_DIA2 for tile-scale), and one local port.
- **Placement hierarchy** — cell → tetrad (`2×2×1` = 4 cells, fully-connected K4) → tile (`2×2×1` tetrads = 16 cells, K4 at the tetrad level). Owner-named 2026-10-15; the datapath stays one module per cell, and the tetrad/tile wrappers exist only for MonBus observation aggregation (outside delta).
- **2 VCs with escape-channel deadlock freedom** — VC0 carries the connected, acyclic escape subrelation; VC1 carries minimal-or-budgeted adaptive routes. VC1 may drain into VC0, but VC0 may never enter VC1.
- **3 QoS classes** — config, latency, and bulk traffic get separate VCs and injection buffers, with strict priority, programmable aging, and a bulk minimum reservation.
- **In-band config with broadcast mode-switch** — per-cell RAM tables load through the data path; a broadcast mode-switch message switches all cells to one of 10 standard fabric modes atomically after a fabric-wide ack barrier.
- **10 standard fabric modes** — mesh, systolic-1D, wavefront-2D, stencil-3D, broadcast, convergecast/reduce, all-to-all/transpose, pipeline+rapids-stream, tetrad all-to-all (K4 via P_DIA), and tile all-to-all (K4-of-tetrads via P_DIA2).
- **Multicast** — VC0-only, BRCP-conformed paths with source-side replication, multiple delivery VCs, and no responses.
- **Systolic/torus package** — per-dimension torus wrap (`--torus=x,y,z`), source-route mode (`--source-route`), and speculative allocation (`--speculation`). Route lookahead is the remaining latency step (issue #120).

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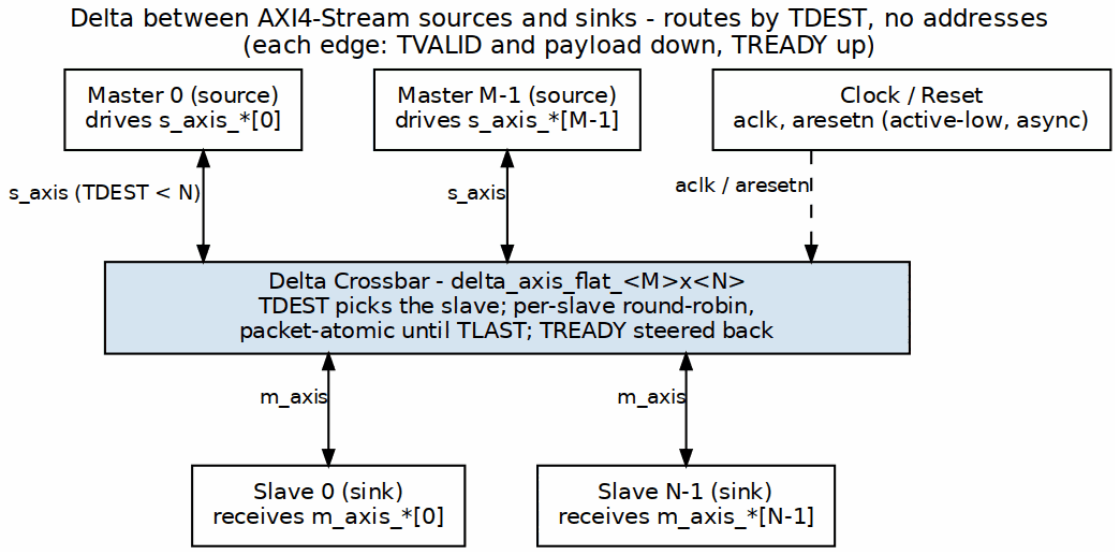
8 System Context

8.1 Where Delta Fits

Delta sits between upstream AXI4-Stream masters and downstream AXI4-Stream slaves. It does not interpret addresses, bursts, or memory attributes; it only routes streams based on `TDEST`.

A typical Delta deployment looks like:

8.1.1 Figure 2.1: Delta System Context



Delta System Context

Multiple masters and multiple slaves attach in parallel. Each master drives one index of the `s_axis_*` arrays; each slave receives one index of the `m_axis_*` arrays.

8.2 Upstream Requirements

- Masters must drive valid AXI4-Stream signals.
- `s_axis_tdest[m]` must be a valid slave index (`0` to `NUM_SLAVES-1`) when `s_axis_tvalid[m]` is asserted.
- Masters must respect `s_axis_tready[m]` backpressure.

8.3 Downstream Requirements

- Slaves must accept valid AXI4-Stream signals.
- Slaves drive `m_axis_tready[s]` to throttle traffic.

8.4 Clocking and Reset

Delta uses a single clock (`aclk`) and an active-low asynchronous reset (`aresetn`). All registered state is reset; combinational decode and mux logic is not registered.

8.5 Relationship to Other Components

Delta Component Context

Component	Role	When to Use
Delta	AXI4-Stream crossbar generator	Streaming fabrics, DSP arrays, sensors
Bridge	Multi-protocol crossbar generator	Memory-mapped AXI4/AXI4-Lite/APB systems
APB Crossbar	APB-only crossbar	Low-bandwidth register-mapped peripherals
RAPIDS	DMA subsystem	Descriptor-based memory transfers

Delta is intentionally narrow in scope: it does one thing (streaming crossbars) and does it without protocol conversion.

8.6 Mesh-Mode Context

Mesh mode extends the same `bin/delta_generator.py` with a `--topology mesh` option. Instead of a flat M×N crossbar it emits a 3-D grid of `delta_mesh_cell` instances with rapids DMA at the boundary and ocelus observers on the links. Cell contents (SERV, CGRA, observers) are outside delta's scope; delta only carries the AXI4-Stream traffic between them.

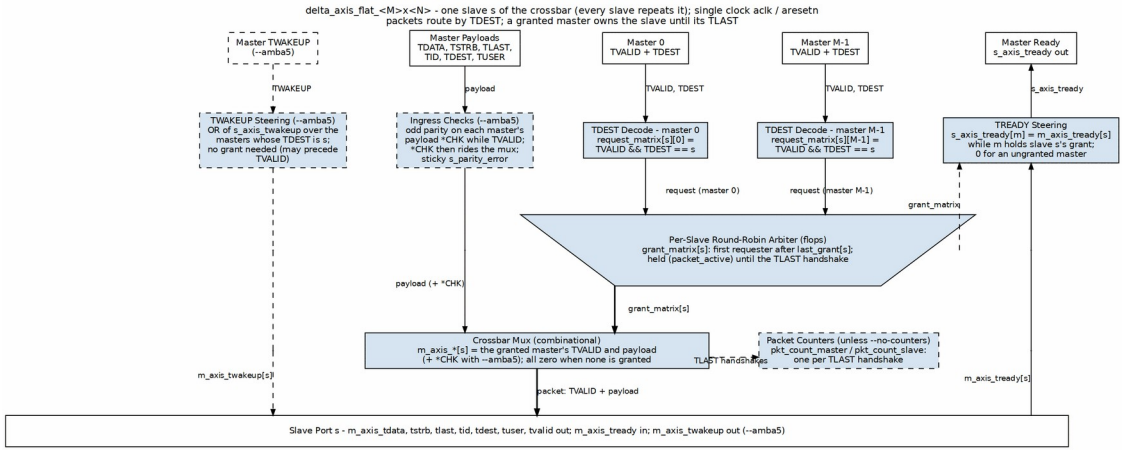
> **IMPLEMENTED** — Mesh mode RTL is generated by `delta_generator.py --topology mesh`; the design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`). The flat crossbar shown in Figure 2.1 remains the default topology.

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9 Block Diagram

9.1 Delta Architecture Overview

9.1.1 Figure 3.1: Delta High-Level Block Diagram



Delta HAS Block Diagram

The diagram follows one slave `s`; every slave repeats it. Each master's TVALID and TDEST are decoded into a request for `s` (center), the per-slave round-robin arbiter (the trapezium) grants one master and holds the grant until that packet's TLAST, and the crossbar mux forwards the granted master's TVALID and payload, which arrive on their own lane at the left. TREADY returns up the right lane to the granted master only. The dashed blocks are build options: `--amba5` adds TWAKEUP steering and the `*CHK` parity checks, and the packet counters are built unless `--no-counters`.

9.2 Functional Blocks

9.2.1 TDEST Decode

Receives `s_axis_tvalid` and `s_axis_tdest` from every master and produces the per-slave `request_matrix`. A request bit is set when a master has a valid transaction whose TDEST selects that slave.

9.2.2 Per-Slave Round-Robin Arbiter

One arbiter per slave. When the slave is idle, it picks the next requesting master in round-robin order. Once a master is granted, the grant is held until TLAST is accepted. This block is the scheduler analog in the house style and is drawn as an inverted trapezium.

9.2.3 Crossbar Mux

A bank of per-slave multiplexers. Each slave mux selects the payload and control signals from the master that currently holds the grant for that slave.

9.2.4 TREADY Steering

Steers each slave's `m_axis_tready` back to the single master that currently owns the grant for that slave. Ungranted masters see `s_axis_tready == 0`.

9.2.5 TWAKEUP Steering (AMBA5, Optional)

When `--amba5` is enabled, this block ORs each master's `s_axis_twakeup` to the slave indicated by `s_axis_tdest`. Because TWAKEUP is a hint, it does not depend on the grant and may assert before TVALID.

9.2.6 Interface Checks (AMBA5, Optional)

With `--amba5`, each master's payload check bits (TDATACHK … TUSERCHK) are checked for odd parity while TVALID is high and then carried through the mux with the beat; TVALIDCHK, TWAKEUPCHK and TREADYCHK are generated by the side that drives the signal and checked by the other (`dataint_parity`). A failed check sets the port's sticky `s_parity_error` / `m_parity_error`.

9.2.7 Packet Counters (Optional)

32-bit counters per master and per slave that increment on every completed packet (`TVALID && TREADY && TLAST`). Removed from the build with `--no-counters`.

9.3 Scalability

Topology Parameter Scaling

Parameter	Typical Range	Impact
NUM_MASTERS	1-32	Linear arbitration and mux growth
NUM_SLAVES	1-256	Linear decode and grant-matrix growth
DATA_WIDTH	8-1024	Linear data-path width
DEST_WIDTH	auto (`clog2(NUM_SLAVES)`)	Sets TDEST width
ID_WIDTH	auto (`clog2(NUM_MASTERS)`)	Sets TID width

9.3.1 Resource Scaling

- **Logic:** O(NUM_MASTERS × NUM_SLAVES) for the grant and request matrices.
- **Data path:** O(NUM_SLAVES × DATA_WIDTH) for the output muxes.
- **Memory:** No BRAM; all state is flip-flops.

10 Data Flow

10.1 Request Flow

1. A master asserts `s_axis_tvalid[m]` and places the target slave index on `s_axis_tdest[m]`.
2. The TDEST decode block sets `request_matrix[s][m]` for the selected slave.
3. If the slave is not already serving another packet, the per-slave round-robin arbiter grants one requesting master.
4. The grant is registered and held until the packet ends on `TLAST`.

10.2 Payload Flow

1. While a grant is active, the crossbar mux selects the granted master's payload.
2. `m_axis_tdata[s]`, `m_axis_tlast[s]`, `m_axis_tdest[s]`, `m_axis_tid[s]`, and `m_axis_tuser[s]` are driven from the granted master.
3. If `TSTRB` is enabled, `m_axis_tstrb[s]` is also forwarded.
4. If `--amba5` is enabled, the payload check bits (`m_axis_tdatachk[s]` through `m_axis_tuserchk[s]`) are forwarded with the beat. They were already checked at the master port, where a failure sets `s_parity_error[m]`.

10.3 Backpressure Flow

1. Each downstream slave drives `m_axis_tready[s]`.
2. The TREADY steering block routes the granted slave's ready back to the owning master.
3. Only the granted master sees `s_axis_tready[m] == 1`; all other masters are stalled.

10.4 Wakeup Flow (AMBA5)

1. A master may assert `s_axis_twakeup[m]` before asserting `s_axis_tvalid[m]`.
2. The TWAKEUP steering block decodes `s_axis_tdest[m]` and ORs the hint to the matching slave.
3. `m_axis_twakeup[s]` may assert with no active grant.

10.5 Packet Boundaries

TLAST marks the final beat of a packet. The arbiter releases the grant on the cycle in which `m_axis_tvalid[s] && m_axis_tready[s] && m_axis_tlast[s]` is true. The next arbitration decision can occur on the following cycle.

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11 Protocol Support

11.1 AXI4-Stream Base Flavor

The default generated crossbar implements the standard AXI4-Stream signal set:

- `TDATA` — data payload
- `TVALID` / `TREADY` — handshake
- `TLAST` — packet boundary
- `TDEST` — destination slave index
- `TID` — transaction/master ID (pass-through)
- `TUSER` — user sideband (pass-through)

This is the byte-identical default; no sideband options are enabled unless requested.

11.2 Optional TSTRB Byte Qualifiers

The `--strb-width N` option adds TSTRB to every master and slave interface. TSTRB is treated as a pass-through sideband: the mux forwards the granted master's TSTRB to the selected slave. Delta does not interpret or modify strobe bits.

11.3 Optional AMBA 5 Sidebands

The `--amba5` option adds:

- `TWAKEUP`: a wakeup hint, decoded from `TDEST` and ORed per slave.
- The AXI5-Stream interface-protection signals of IHI 0051B chapter 5 (`Check_Type = Odd_Parity_Byte_All`): `TDATACHK`, `TSTRBCHK` (with `TSTRB`), `TLASTCHK`, `TIDCHK`, `TDESTCHK`, `TUSERCHK`, `TVALIDCHK`, `TREADYCHK` and `TWAKEUPCHK`, all odd parity. The spec fixes the widths at one check bit per 8 bits.
- Sticky `s_parity_error` / `m_parity_error` flags per port.

The crossbar checks the payload check bits on ingress and carries them to the granted slave unchanged. It generates the control check bits for the signals it drives and checks the ones it receives. The generated ports match the `rtl/amba/axis5/*` modules. See Chapter 4, AXI-Stream Rich Interface, for the full table.

11.4 What Delta Does Not Support

Delta is intentionally AXI4-Stream only. It does **not** support:

- AXI4 memory-mapped transactions (AW/AR/W/B/R channels).
- AXI4-Lite register-mapped access.
- APB transfers.
- Burst lengths, address phases, or memory attributes.
- Dynamic reconfiguration of the crossbar dimensions.

For memory-mapped fabrics, use the sibling `bridge` or `lattice-apbx-xbar` components.

11.5 Protocol Compliance Summary

Protocol Support Matrix

Feature	Base Flavor	Rich Flavor	Notes
TVALID/ TREADY handshake	Yes	Yes	Standard AXI4-Stream
TLAST packet boundary	Yes	Yes	Grant release on TLAST
TDEST routing	Yes	Yes	Direct slave index
TID/TUSER pass-through	Yes	Yes	Unmodified
TSTRB	No	Yes	`--strb-width N`
TWAKEUP	No	Yes	`--amba5`
T*CHK interface parity (IHI 0051B ch. 5, odd)	No	Yes	`--amba5`

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12 AXI-Stream Base Interface

12.1 Master Interface (S_AXIS)

Each master port is indexed by `m` in the range `0` to `NUM_MASTERS-1`.

Base Master Interface Signals

Signal	Width	Direction	Description
`s_axis_tdata[m]`	`DATA_WIDTH`	Input	Data payload.
`s_axis_tvalid[m]`	1	Input	Valid indicator. When high, `s_axis_tdest[m]` selects the target slave.
`s_axis_tready[m]`	1	Output	Ready / backpressure. Driven from the granted slave's `m_axis_tready`.
`s_axis_tlast[m]`	1	Input	Packet boundary. The final beat of a packet.
`s_axis_tdest[m]`	`DEST_WIDTH`	Input	Target slave index. Must be `< NUM_SLAVES` when `tvalid` is asserted.
`s_axis_tid[m]`	`ID_WIDTH`	Input	Transaction ID. Pass-through to `m_axis_tid`.
`s_axis_tuser[m]`	`USER_WIDTH`	Input	User sideband. Pass-through to `m_axis_tuser`.

12.2 Slave Interface (M_AXIS)

Each slave port is indexed by `s` in the range `0` to `NUM_SLAVES-1`.

Base Slave Interface Signals

Signal	Width	Direction	Description
`m_axis_tdata[s]`	`DATA_WIDTH`	Output	Data payload from the granted master.
`m_axis_tvalid[s]`	1	Output	Valid indicator. Asserted when a grant is active and the selected master is valid.
`m_axis_tready[s]`	1	Input	Ready / backpressure from the downstream slave.
`m_axis_tlast[s]`	1	Output	Packet boundary. Forwarded from the granted master.
`m_axis_tdest[s]`	`DEST_WIDTH`	Output	Target slave index. Pass-through from the granted master.
`m_axis_tid[s]`	`ID_WIDTH`	Output	Transaction ID. Pass-through from the granted master.
`m_axis_tuser[s]`	`USER_WIDTH`	Output	User sideband. Pass-through from the granted master.

12.3 Signal Semantics

- `TVALID` may be asserted without `TREADY`; the transfer completes only when both are high.
- `TREADY` for an ungranted master is always low.
- `TDEST` must be stable while `TVALID` is asserted and the master is waiting for grant or transfer.
- `TID` and `TUSER` are pass-through and must be stable on every valid beat.

13 AXI-Stream Rich Interface (TSTRB + AMBA5)

13.1 Rich Master Interface (S_AXIS)

When `--strb-width N` and/or `--amba5` are used, the master interface adds the following signals in addition to the base set. The check signals are IHI 0051B chapter 5 (`Check_Type = Odd_Parity_Byte_All`). Names and widths match `rtl/amba/axis5/*`.

Rich Master Interface Additional Signals

Signal	Width	Direction	Presence	Description
`s_axis_tstrb[m]`	`STRB_WIDTH`	Input	`--strb-width N`	Byte qualifier / strobe. Pass-through to `m_axis_tstrb`.
`s_axis_twakeup[m]`	1	Input	`--amba5`	Wakeup hint. May assert before `TVALID`.
`s_axis_tdatachk[m]`	`TDATACHK_W = DATA_WIDTH/8`	Input	`--amba5`	Odd parity per `TDATA` byte. Checked, then carried.
`s_axis_tstrbchk[m]`	`TSTRBCHK_W = ceil(STRB_WIDTH/8)`	Input	`--amba5` and `--strb-width N`	Odd parity over `TSTRB`. Checked, then carried.
`s_axis_tlastchk[m]`	1	Input	`--amba5`	~`TLAST`. Checked, then carried.
`s_axis_tidchk[m]`	`TIDCHK_W = ceil(ID_WIDTH/8)`	Input	`--amba5`	Odd parity over `TID`. Checked, then carried.
`s_axis_tdestchk[m]`	`TDESTCHK_W = ceil(DEST_WIDTH/8)`	Input	`--amba5`	Odd parity over `TDEST`. Checked, then carried.
`s_axis_tuserchk[m]`	`TUSERCHK_W =`	Input	`--amba5`	Odd parity over `TUSER`. Checked,

Signal	Width	Direction	Presence	Description
	ceil(USER_WIDTH/8)			then carried.
s_axis_tvalidchk[m]	1	Input	--amba5	~TVALID. Checked every cycle out of reset.
s_axis_treadychk[m]	1	Output	--amba5	~TREADY, generated by the crossbar.
s_axis_twakeupchk[m]	1	Input	--amba5	~TWAKEUP. Checked every cycle out of reset.
s_parity_error[m]	1	Output	--amba5	Sticky. Set by any check failure on master port m. Cleared by aresetn.

13.2 Rich Slave Interface (M_AXIS)

Rich Slave Interface Additional Signals

Signal	Width	Direction	Presence	Description
m_axis_tstrb[s]	STRB_WIDTH	Output	--strb-width N	Byte qualifier from the granted master.
m_axis_twakeup[s]	1	Output	--amba5	Wakeup hint. OR of all masters whose TDEST selects slave s.
m_axis_tdatachk[s], m_axis_tstrbchk[s], m_axis_tlastchk[s], m_axis_tidchk[s], m_axis_tdestchk[s], m_axis_tuserchk[s]	as on the master side	Output	--amba5 (tstrbchk also needs --strb-width N)	Payload check bits of the granted master, carried unchanged. All ones while no master is granted.
m_axis_tvalidchk[s]	1	Output	--amba5	~TVALID, generated by the crossbar.
m_axis_treadychk[s]	1	Input	--amba5	~TREADY. Checked every cycle out of reset.
m_axis_twakeupchk[s]	1	Output	--amba5	~TWAKEUP, generated by the crossbar.
m_parity_error[s]	1	Output	--amba5	Sticky. Set by a bad TREADYCHK on slave port s. Cleared by aresetn.

13.3 TSTRB Semantics

- `TSTRB` is treated as an opaque byte-qualifier sideband.
- The crossbar forwards the granted master's `TSTRB` to the selected slave.
- Delta does not gate `TVALID` based on `TSTRB` or modify strobe bits.

13.4 TWAKEUP Semantics

TWAKEUP is an AMBA 5 hint, not a handshake signal:

- A master may assert `s_axis_twakeup[m]` before `s_axis_tvalid[m]` to wake the target slave.
- The crossbar decodes `s_axis_tdest[m]` and ORs the hint to the indicated slave.
- `m_axis_twakeup[s]` may be high while `m_axis_tvalid[s]` is low.
- No grant is required for TWAKEUP steering.

13.5 Check-Signal Semantics (IHI 0051B Chapter 5)

- Parity is odd. A check bit and the bits it covers hold an odd number of ones. Bit `[n]` covers bits `[8n+7:8n]`, and the top bit covers a short remainder (section 5.3).
- Payload checks (`TDATACHK` through `TUSERCHK`) are checked only while `TVALID` is high. `TVALIDCHK`, `TREADYCHK` and `TWAKEUPCHK` are checked on every cycle out of reset.
- Payload check bits are carried end to end with the beat, never regenerated. A bad bit at a master port stays bad at the slave port.
- A failed check sets the port's sticky error flag. It does not stall, drop or alter the beat.
- Every check bit is computed or checked by a `rtl/common/dataint_parity` instance. The compile closure of a generated `--amba5` crossbar includes `rtl/common/filelists/dataint_parity.f`.

13.6 Parameter Implications

Rich-Flavor Parameter-to-Port Mapping

Option	Generated Parameter	Port Effect
`--strb-width N`	`STRB_WIDTH = N`	Adds `s_axis_tstrb` and `m_axis_tstrb` arrays.
`--amba5`	`TDATACHK_W`, `TIDCHK_W`, `TDESTCHK_W`, `TUSERCHK_W` (plus `TSTRBCHK_W` with `--strb-width`), each derived from its payload width	Adds `TWAKEUP`, the nine check signals and the two `*_parity_error` arrays. Requires a whole-byte `--data-width`.

14 Clock and Reset

14.1 Clock

Clock Signal

Signal	Width	Direction	Description
`aclk`	1	Input	Positive-edge clock for all registered state.

All registered logic (grants, `last_grant`, packet-active flags, counters) is clocked on the rising edge of `aclk`. Combinational decode and mux logic is not registered.

14.2 Reset

Reset Signal

Signal	Width	Direction	Description
`aresetn`	1	Input	Active-low asynchronous reset.

`aresetn` resets all registered state:

- `grant_matrix` to zero.
- `last_grant` to zero.
- `packet_active` to zero.
- Packet counters to zero.

The reset assertion is asynchronous; de-assertion is synchronous to `aclk` in the checked-in RTL through the `ALWAYS_FF_RST` macro.

14.3 Clocking Rules

- All masters and slaves share the same `aclk`.
- Delta does not contain clock-domain crossing logic.
- Inputs are sampled on the rising edge of `aclk`; outputs are driven combinationally or from registers.

14.4 Reset Recommendations

- Assert `aresetn` for at least several clock cycles after power and clock stability.
- Do not rely on Delta's outputs during reset; combinational mux outputs may be zero or undefined during reset.

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15 Throughput Characteristics

15.1 Aggregate Throughput

Because each slave has its own arbiter and mux, aggregate throughput scales with the number of slaves. In the best case — every master targets a different slave and every slave is ready — the crossbar can accept one beat per master per cycle.

15.2 Per-Slave Throughput

When multiple masters contend for the same slave, the round-robin arbiter gives each contending master an equal share of the slave's bandwidth. With K contending masters, each sees approximately 1/K of the slave's available bandwidth.

15.3 Head-of-Line Blocking

A master blocked on one slave does not block traffic to other slaves. Each slave arbiter is independent. However, a master that targets a heavily contended slave will wait until its round-robin turn and until the current packet completes.

15.4 Throughput Targets

Throughput Targets

Metric	Target	Notes
Per-slave throughput	Up to 1 transfer/cycle	When one master continuously feeds one ready slave.
Aggregate throughput	Up to NUM_MASTERS transfers/cycle	When all masters target different ready slaves.
Mixed-traffic throughput	≥ 0.7 transfers/cycle per active master	Under moderate contention in the performance model.

15.5 Factors That Reduce Throughput

- Contention for the same slave.
- Downstream backpressure (`m_axis_tready[s] == 0`).
- Multi-beat packets that lock the slave until `TLAST`.
- Arbitration overhead of one cycle when switching masters after `TLAST`.

---

16 Latency Analysis

16.1 Cycle Breakdown

The generated flat crossbar has a fixed two-cycle latency from master input to slave output:

Latency Cycle Breakdown

Cycle	Action
0	Master asserts `s_axis_tvalid` and `s_axis_tdest`.
1	TDEST decode produces `request_matrix`; arbiter registers the grant.
2	Crossbar mux drives `m_axis_tdata`, `m_axis_tvalid`, etc. to the slave.

16.2 Arbitration Delay

If the target slave is idle when the request arrives, the grant is registered on the next rising edge of `aclk`. If the slave is busy serving another packet, the new request waits until the current packet's TLAST is accepted.

16.3 Backpressure Latency

`m_axis_tready[s]` propagates combinationally through the TREADY steering logic to `s_axis_tready[m]`. There is no additional registered delay on the backpressure path.

16.4 Latency Targets

Latency Targets

Configuration	Latency	Notes
Flat crossbar, idle slave	2 cycles	Arbitration + registered grant.
Flat crossbar, contended slave	2 + wait cycles	Wait depends on current packet length.

16.5 Frequency Target

The flat crossbar is intended to run at **≥ 300 MHz** on Xilinx UltraScale+ devices for typical configurations (e.g., 4×16 @ 64-bit). Actual Fmax depends on device, tool settings, and floorplanning.

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17 Resources

17.1 Estimates from the Performance Model

The `bin/delta_performance_model.py` script provides empirical resource estimates based on the flat topology. Values below are planning estimates, not synthesis results.

Resource Estimates

Configuration	LUTs	FFs	Notes
4×16 @ 64-bit	~1,536	~1,536	Base flavor, with counters.
2×4 @ 32-bit	~200	~150	Small test configuration.
4×16 @ 64-bit, no counters	~1,400	~1,200	`--no-counters` saves FF area.

17.2 Scaling Laws

- **LUTs:** Grow roughly as `NUM_MASTERS × NUM_SLAVES` for arbitration plus `NUM_SLAVES × DATA_WIDTH` for the data mux.
- **FFs:** Grow roughly as `NUM_MASTERS × NUM_SLAVES` for the grant matrix and `last_grant` storage, plus `NUM_MASTERS + NUM_SLAVES` for packet counters when enabled.
- **BRAM:** None. Delta is a pure-logic implementation.

17.3 Area Optimization Knobs

Area Optimization Options

Knob	Effect
`--no-counters`	Removes `pkt_count_master` and `pkt_count_slave` arrays.
Smaller `NUM_MASTERS`/`NUM_SLAVES`	Linear reduction in control logic.
Smaller `DATA_WIDTH`	Linear reduction in data mux area.
Disable richness options	Removes `TSTRB` muxing, and with `--amba5` off removes the `TWAKEUP` decode, the check-signal mux and the per-port `dataint_parity` checkers.

18 System Requirements

18.1 Toolchain Requirements

- **Synthesis:** Any SystemVerilog-2017-capable synthesis tool (Vivado, Yosys, Genus, etc.).
- **Simulation:** Any SystemVerilog simulator; cocotb is the planned verification framework.
- **Lint:** Verilator (`--lint-only`) is used for quick sanity checks.

18.2 Runtime Requirements

- Single clock domain: all `s_axis_*` and `m_axis_*` interfaces use `aclk`.
- Active-low asynchronous reset: `aresetn` must be asserted at power-up.
- All upstream masters and downstream slaves must implement the AXI4-Stream handshake.

18.3 Interface Assumptions

- Masters drive valid `TDEST` values (`0` to `NUM_SLAVES-1`).
- Slaves drive `m_axis_tready` independently.
- No master changes `TDEST` while waiting for a grant.
- `TID` and `TUSER` widths match the generated parameters.

18.4 Integration Checklist

- ☐ Confirm `DATA_WIDTH`, `NUM_MASTERS`, and `NUM_SLAVES` match the system.
- ☐ Confirm `DEST_WIDTH` and `ID_WIDTH` are wide enough for the generated module.
- ☐ Decide whether `TSTRB` or AMBA 5 sidebands are needed.
- ☐ Decide whether packet counters are needed (default on; use `--no-counters` to remove).
- ☐ Connect `aclk` and `aresetn` from the system.
- ☐ Verify downstream slaves can accept backpressure.
- ☐ Run `verilator --lint-only` on the generated RTL.

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19 Parameter Configuration

19.1 Generated Module Parameters

Generated Module Parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
DATA_WIDTH	CLI --data-width	Width of TDATA in bits.
DEST_WIDTH	clog2(NUM_SLAVES)	Width of TDEST.
ID_WIDTH	clog2(NUM_MASTERS)	Width of TID.
USER_WIDTH	CLI --user-width	Width of TUSER.
NUM_MASTERS	CLI --masters	Number of master interfaces.
NUM_SLAVES	CLI --slaves	Number of slave interfaces.
STRB_WIDTH	CLI --strb-width	Width of TSTRB (only when --strb-width is used).
TDATACHK_W	DATA_WIDTH / 8	Width of TDATACHK (only with --amba5).
TSTRBCHK_W	(STRB_WIDTH + 7) / 8	Width of TSTRBCHK (only with --amba5 and --strb-width).
TIDCHK_W	(ID_WIDTH + 7) / 8	Width of TIDCHK (only with --amba5).
TDESTCHK_W	(DEST_WIDTH + 7) / 8	Width of TDESTCHK (only with --amba5).
TUSERCHK_W	(USER_WIDTH + 7) / 8	Width of TUSERCHK (only with --amba5).

19.2 Generator CLI Options

Generator Command-Line Options

Option	Values	Default	Description
`--topology`	`flat` only	`flat`	Crossbar topology (tree/both retired 2026-10-12).
`--masters`	1-32	required	Number of master interfaces.
`--slaves`	1-256	required	Number of slave interfaces.
`--data-width`	8-1024	64	`TDATA` width in bits.
`--user-width`	1-32	1	`TUSER` width in bits.
`--strb-width`	≥ 0	0	`TSTRB` width; 0 omits `TSTRB`.
`--amba5`	flag	off	Emit AMBA 5 `TWAKEUP`, the IHI 0051B ch. 5 check signals and the per-port `*_parity_error` flags. Requires `--data-width` to be a multiple of 8.
`--no-counters`	flag	off	Disable packet counters.
`--output-dir`	path	`../rtl`	Output directory for generated SystemVerilog.

19.3 Example Configurations

19.3.1 Base flavor 4×16 @ 64-bit

```
python3 bin/delta_generator.py \
    --topology flat --masters 4 --slaves 16 --data-width 64 \
    --output-dir rtl/
```

19.3.2 Rich flavor 2×4 @ 32-bit with TSTRB and AMBA5

```
python3 bin/delta_generator.py \
    --topology flat --masters 2 --slaves 4 --data-width 32 \
    --strb-width 4 --amba5 --output-dir /tmp/delta_amba5/
cp /tmp/delta_amba5/delta_axis_flat_2x4.sv
rtl_test/delta_axis_flat_2x4_strb_amba5.sv
```

The generator names its output by shape. Writing straight into `rtl_test/` would overwrite the plain `delta_axis_flat_2x4.sv`. The compile closure is `rtl_test/filelists/delta_axis_flat_2x4_strb_amba5.f`, which `-f` includes `rtl/common/filelists/dataint_parity.f`.

19.3.3 Base flavor without counters

```
python3 bin/delta_generator.py \
    --topology flat --masters 4 --slaves 16 --data-width 64 \
    --no-counters --output-dir rtl/
```

20 Verification Strategy

20.1 Current Status

As of 2026-10-12, Delta has one cocotb suite in `dv/tests/`. It covers the `--amba5` flavor through the checked-in example `rtl_test/delta_axis_flat_2x4_strb_amba5.sv` (2x4, 32-bit, TSTRB), using a thin flattening harness (`dv/tb/delta_axis_flat_2x4_strb_amba5_th.sv`) and RDS-DV AXIS5 BFMs on every port:

- **routing:** every master sends to every slave at once. Each slave must receive exactly its beats, every beat must pass the slave BFM's odd-parity check, the crossbar-driven TVALIDCHK/TWAKEUPCHK/TREADYCHK must equal the inversion of their signals on every cycle, and no error flag may set. At func and full the BFMs add random VALID gaps and READY stalls.
- **wakeup:** TWAKEUP with no TVALID reaches only the TDEST slave, with TWAKEUPCHK inverted.
- **chk_errors:** a bad TDATACHK, a bad TVALIDCHK and a bad TREADYCHK each set the right sticky flag and no other. Reset clears it.

Run it with `make clean-all && make run-all-func-parallel` in `dv/tests/`. The base flavor (`rtl/delta_axis_flat_4x16.sv` and the plain `rtl_test/` shapes) still has no simulation suite. It is verified by lint and review only.

20.2 Generator Verification

- Run `bin/delta_generator.py` for several configurations.
- Compare output against checked-in reference RTL (`rtl/delta_axis_flat_4x16.sv`, `rtl_test/delta_axis_flat_*.sv`).
- Verify that default output is byte-identical to pre-2026-10-12 generations.

20.3 Lint Verification

```
verilator --lint-only rtl/delta_axis_flat_4x16.sv
```

Or use the provided `rtl/Makefile`:

```
cd rtl && make verilator
```

20.4 Planned RTL Verification

Still to add:

- All master-to-slave routing combinations.
- Concurrent traffic to the same slave (round-robin fairness).
- Concurrent traffic to different slaves (no crosstalk).
- Backpressure stress tests.
- Packet atomicity verification (no interleaving before `TLAST`).
- Base-flavor equivalents of the `--amba5` suite (the AMBA 5 check signals are covered today).
- Reset behavior.

20.5 Formal Properties

When `FORMAL` is defined, the generated RTL includes:

- One-hot grant assertion per slave.
- TDEST range assertion per master.

These can be exercised with a SystemVerilog formal tool.

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21 Synthesis and Implementation

21.1 Synthesis Flow

The generated module is a flat SystemVerilog file intended for standard synthesis:

```
# Example Vivado flow
read_verilog rtl/delta_axis_flat_4x16.sv
synth_design -top delta_axis_flat_4x16 -part xczu7ev-ffvc1156-2-e
```

21.2 Timing Considerations

- The critical path is typically from `s_axis_tvalid/tdest` through the decode and mux to `m_axis_tdata/tvalid`.
- Because the grant is registered, the mux select is stable for a full cycle once a grant is made.
- The `TREADY` path is combinational from `m_axis_tready` to `s_axis_tready`.

21.3 Floorplanning Suggestions

- For large crossbars, consider registering `s_axis_tdata` at the master boundary if the combinational mux path is too long.
- Keep related master/slave groups physically close to reduce routing congestion.
- If Fmax is insufficient, the generator supports `--no-counters` and reduced `DATA_WIDTH` to ease timing.

21.4 Implementation Checklist

- ☐ Synthesize the generated module in the target tool.
- ☐ Check setup/hold timing on `aclk`.
- ☐ Verify `aresetn` deassertion is synchronous to `aclk`.
- ☐ Run a post-implementation functional simulation if the design is modified after generation.

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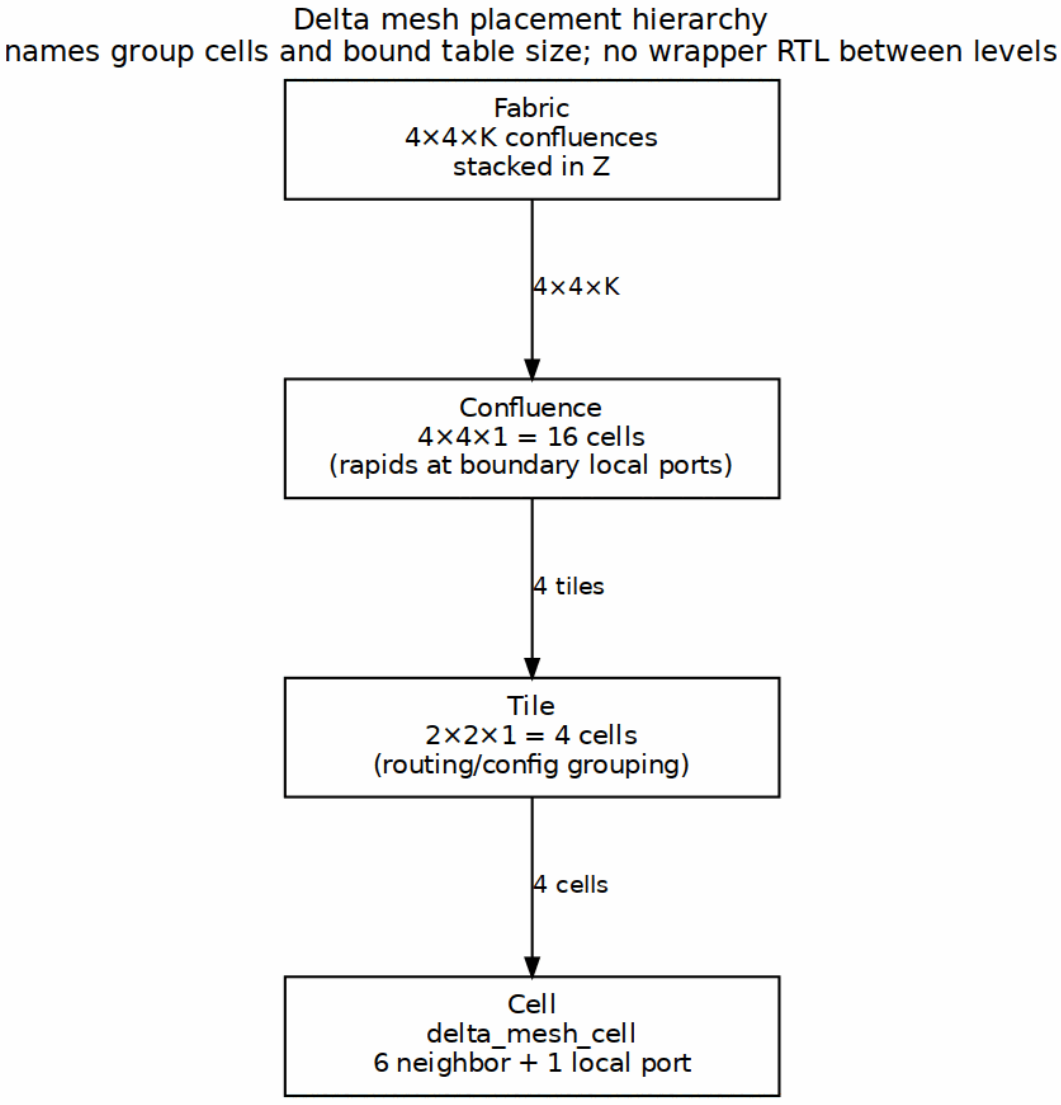
22 Mesh Hierarchy

IMPLEMENTED (2026-10-15 amendment) — Mesh mode emits one module, `delta_mesh_cell`, and a fabric top. The owner re-named the hierarchy levels on 2026-10-15: **tetrad** = 2×2×1 cells, **tile** = 2×2×1 tetrads. For the datapath these are placement and naming; the tetrad/tile wrappers exist only to aggregate MonBus observation streams and live in the compute-engine tile IP, not in delta. The canonical tile definition is `TILE_SPEC.md`. This chapter's old name "confluence" is pre-2026-10-15 history.

22.1 Placement Levels

Delta's mesh groups identical cells into named levels so that routing tables, config images, and rapids attachment points can be named without forcing a separate datapath wrapper at every level.

22.1.1 Figure 7.1: Delta Mesh Placement Hierarchy



Delta Mesh Hierarchy

22.2 Cell

A cell is `delta_mesh_cell`, the one RTL module the generator emits for mesh mode. It has nine ports: six axis neighbor ports (±X, ±Y, ±Z), two instances of the conceptual diagonal axis (P_DIA at the tetrad scale and P_DIA2 at the tile scale), and one local port. A cell forwards flits by looking up a destination coordinate in a RAM routing table and applying credit-based flow control per VC.

22.3 Tetrad

A tetrad is 2×2×1 cells — four cells arranged in X and Y, one deep in Z. The four cells are fully connected as a K4 clique: perimeter edges over ±X/±Y plus both diagonals over P_DIA. The tetrad is a placement/config grouping and the first level of MonBus aggregation; an intra-tetrad hop is an ordinary cell hop.

22.4 Tile

A tile is 2×2×1 tetrads — sixteen cells, or four tetrads. The four tetrads are themselves fully connected as a K4 at tetrad scale: shared ±X/±Y boundaries for edge-adjacent tetrads and P_DIA2 for diagonal-tetrad pairs. Rapids DMA attaches at the local ports of boundary cells. The tile wrapper (outside delta) is the second level of MonBus aggregation.

22.5 Fabric

A fabric is 4×4×K tiles stacked in Z. The recursion is planar: the Z dimension lives between tile layers. The generator produces a fabric top that instantiates the `cells-x × cells-y × cells-z` grid of `delta_mesh_cell`, parameterizes coordinate widths and per-dimension wrap links, and exposes boundary local ports as rapids attachment points.

22.6 Why This Grouping

The grouping borrows the superswitch idea seen in ECLIPSE: clustering cells so a message can reach any cell in a local group cheaply. Delta keeps the naming and table-bounding benefit but does not promise single-cycle traversal across a tetrad or tile. That trade keeps the cell simple — one module, one set of tables, one set of allocators — while still letting software reason about locality.

22.7 Observation Modules (2026-10-15 amendment)

Every cell emits exactly one MonBus observer stream. The tetrad and tile wrappers (compute-eng-ip tile IP, not delta) aggregate these streams up the hierarchy: four cell streams merge into one tetrad-level MonBus, and four tetrad streams merge into one tile-top-level MonBus. The datapath is unchanged; the wrappers are placement-only observation aggregation. MonBus aggregation is a parallel effort and is not part of this delta task.

23 Cell and Flit

23.1 Cell Ports

IMPLEMENTED — `delta_mesh_cell` is generated by `delta_generator.py --topology mesh`. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Each cell has nine AXI4-Stream interfaces:

- **6 axis neighbor ports** — +X, −X, +Y, −Y, +Z, −Z. Wrap links for any dimension are parameterizable with `--torus=x,y,z`.
- **1 diagonal tetrad port (P_DIA)** — connects the cell to its diagonal mate inside the same 2×2×1 tetrad, making every tetrad a fully-connected K4.
- **1 diagonal tile port (P_DIA2)** — connects the cell to its diagonal-tetrad corner mate inside the same 4×4×1 tile, making the four tetrads of a tile a fully-connected K4.
- **1 local port** — host-facing. Boundary cells expose this port for rapids DMA attachment; interior cells connect to local compute (SERV, CGRA, ocelus) outside delta's scope.

Conceptually, P_DIA and P_DIA2 are two instances of a single diagonal axis: one in-plane diagonal axis at tetrad scale and one at tile scale, plus the out-of-plane Z axis and the in-plane X/Y axes, give the cell four axes and nine ports.

All ports carry `TDATA`, `TVALID`, `TREADY`, and `TLAST`. The head beat also carries the packet header in `TUSER`. AMBA 5 sidebands (`TWAKEUP`, `TDATACHK` and the chapter 5 check signals) are flat-mode only in v1 — mesh mode rejects `--amba5` at generation time (mesh ports carry no sidebands; the check-signal budget is an open item if a monitored mesh port is needed).

23.2 Clock and Reset

The mesh cell uses a single clock (`aclk`) and the active-low asynchronous reset (`aresetn`) common to the rest of delta. This is a deliberate simplification *against* the GALS direction common in the NoC literature. The trade: timing closure and generator predictability win over per-link clock flexibility. If a future system needs independent clock domains, that becomes a boundary problem solved outside the cell.

23.3 Flit Format

A flit is one DATA_WIDTH beat. A packet is a head flit, zero or more body flits, and a TLAST tail beat. The head flit carries the header in TUSER; body and tail flits carry only payload and TLAST.

23.3.1 Head-Flit Header Fields

Head-flit header fields carried in TUSER on the head beat.

Field	Width	Purpose
dest coord	3×COORD_W	X, Y, Z destination. COORD_W is sized by the fabric dimensions.
src coord	3×COORD_W	X, Y, Z source, used for responses and counters.
QoS class	2	0 = config, 1 = latency, 2 = bulk.
VC	1	Assigned at injection per §6.
multicast	1	Set for multicast packets; group/mask reference is mode-specific.
misroute budget	3	Decremented on each non-minimal hop; packet dropped and counted at 0.
source-route ptr	4	Indexes an inline port list when source-route mode is active.
packet ID	4	Tolerates reordering at endpoints under multi-VC or adaptive routing.

Proposed (2026-10-16, not implemented): the compute-engine tile proposes extending this header with a `level` field in the coordinates, a payload type (`cfg` / `prog` / `mem`), a length and a target address. The description lives in TILE_SPEC.md Section 11, not here.

Payload streams pass transparently through the cell once the head beat has supplied the route. This is the same pass-through principle used by flat mode's TDEST handling, only the routing information now lives in TUSER rather than TDEST.

24 Routing and Configuration

24.1 Routing Tables

> **IMPLEMENTED** — `delta_mesh_cell` contains a RAM routing table. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Each `delta_mesh_cell` holds a RAM routing table. The lookup key is `(destination coordinate, QoS class)` and the result is `(output port mask, VC)`. Because QoS classes are isolated, each class can have an independent route to the same destination, giving path diversity without changing the cell datapath. The output port mask is 9 bits wide, one bit per cell port.

The table is a standard node-table implementation: one lookup per hop. That lookup penalty is why source-route mode (§7.3) exists for latency-critical systolic schedules.

24.2 Reset Default

At reset every cell loads a hardwired dimension-ordered route toward the rapids boundary. The route is connected and acyclic by construction, so it forms a safe bootstrap path even before software loads custom tables. In-band config packets ride this default route.

24.3 Table Constraints

The generator and the table-load checker enforce three rules that keep the mesh deadlock-free:

- VC0 entries must form a connected, acyclic subrelation in the extended channel-dependency graph. This is checked at table-load time, not just at reset.
- VC1 entries must be minimal, or must carry a misroute budget and create no indirect dependence on VC0.
- VC1→VC0 transitions are permitted at any hop; VC0→VC1 transitions are forbidden.

24.4 In-Band Configuration

Config packets target a reserved destination and are intercepted by the cell's ejection block instead of being delivered to the local port. The config format is `{op (read/write), entry index, entry data}`. Reads return response packets to the source so software can load-verify.

Per-cell unicast loading is the primary way to install custom routes: N cells × M entries are written at boot, and individual entries can be rewritten at runtime. Config traffic uses QoS class 0 and the reset-default route; a boundary cell or rapids injects the config stream.

24.5 Broadcast Mode-Switch

A broadcast mode-switch message switches the entire fabric to one of the standard modes. Every cell stores generator-emitted images for the standard modes in ROM or preloaded RAM. The new mode applies only after a fabric-wide ack barrier: each cell returns a config read-response ack, and the injector treats the mode as active only when all acks are in. No packet straddles two modes.

Mode 0 is custom — the per-cell unicast tables. Modes 1-10 are the standard fabric modes (modes 9 and 10 added 2026-10-15 for the P_DIA/P_DIA2 diagonal-axis K4 images). Switching among standard modes does not touch the custom tables.

25 Flow Control and Deadlock

25.1 Credit-Based Flow Control

> **IMPLEMENTED** — `delta_mesh_cell` uses credit-based flow control per VC. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Delta's mesh uses credit-based flow control per VC. Each output port tracks the number of free buffer slots in the downstream neighbor. A flit leaves only when a credit is available, and a credit returns only after the downstream cell has consumed the flit. Credit-counter depth is sized to cover round-trip latency; undersizing drops the channel duty factor below one.

25.2 Two Virtual Channels

The mesh has 2 VCs:

- **VC0** — the escape channel. It carries only reset-default and turn-model-conforming routes that form a connected, acyclic subrelation.
- **VC1** — the adaptive channel. It may carry minimal routes or routes with a bounded misroute budget.

This is Duato's Protocol: one adaptive channel set plus one deterministic escape set. The escape set breaks any cycle that could form in the adaptive set.

25.3 VC Transition Rules

A packet may move from VC1 to VC0 at any hop. VC0 to VC1 is forbidden. Because every VC1 packet can always drain into VC0, cycles in the adaptive channel cannot close into a deadlock.

25.4 Torus Wrap and the Dateline Rule

Per-dimension torus wrap (`--torus=x,y,z`) restores edge symmetry and halves diameter, but a wrap channel creates a cycle that plain dimension-ordered routing cannot break. For each wrapped dimension, one designated wrap channel participates in VC0 only through the escape subrelation. Other wrap traffic uses VC1 with the misroute budget. This dateline rule keeps the 2-VC budget sufficient even with wrap links.

25.5 Livelock

Non-minimal routing is the only source of livelock. The misroute budget in the head flit bounds it: every non-minimal hop decrements the budget, and when it reaches zero the packet is dropped and counted. Minimal routing is the normal case; the budget exists to bound VC1 alternates.

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26 Quality of Service

26.1 Three Traffic Classes

IMPLEMENTED — QoS arbitration is built into `delta_mesh_cell`. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Delta's mesh defines 3 QoS classes:

- **Class 0 — config/control** — highest priority; must never be blocked by data traffic.
- **Class 1 — latency** — interactive or latency-sensitive traffic.
- **Class 2 — bulk** — throughput traffic that can tolerate delay.

This split mirrors the control/data-plane priority split common in NPU practice.

26.2 Strict Priority With Aging

Every output port uses strict priority among the classes. To prevent starvation of lower-priority traffic, the arbiter includes programmable aging: a lower-priority request that has waited too long is temporarily promoted above a newer higher-priority request.

Aging alone is not enough for class 2 under heavy class-0/1 load. A bulk minimum reservation guarantees that some fraction of each cycle is spent serving bulk traffic.

26.3 Non-Interference

Each class has separate VCs and separate injection buffers. Shared buffers let tree-saturation traffic in one class block unrelated traffic even with priority bits, so delta keeps the resources separate. Config class traffic gets its own VC0 slice so control can never be bulk-blocked.

26.4 Per-Class Routes

The routing table is keyed by `(destination, QoS class)`, so each class can follow an independent route to the same destination. Latency class might take a low-contention path while bulk class takes the shortest physical path.

26.5 Within-Class Fairness

Per-flow weighted round-robin or deficit round-robin within a class is a known enhancement. It is deferred until a user needs it; the current design provides class isolation and class-level fairness only.

27 Multicast

27.1 VC0 Only

IMPLEMENTED — multicast is built into `delta_mesh_cell`. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Multicast packets use VC0 only. Restricting multicast to the escape channel keeps the multicast paths inside the same connected, acyclic subrelation used by unicast traffic, so multicast adds no new channel dependencies beyond the unicast deadlock proof.

27.2 BRCP-Conformed Paths

Multicast routes are table entries that produce an output port mask instead of a single output. The set of paths a multicast can take is constrained to conform to the base unicast routing (BRCP — base routing conformed path-based multicast). A cell replicates a packet only onto ports that the unicast tables would also use.

27.3 Source-Side Replication

When a packet must fan out, the branching cell enqueues one copy per destination port. This source-side replication discipline avoids broadcasting every packet everywhere and filtering later. Incremental allocation serves whichever masked outputs are free each cycle and releases the input only after all destinations have been served.

27.4 Multiple Delivery VCs

Multicast reception can deadlock even when the forward paths are correct, because multiple deliveries can compete for the same buffer. Each cell therefore provides multiple delivery VCs for multicast reception.

27.5 No Responses

Multicast connections do not carry responses. Responses create merge volume and ordering problems that are better handled by unicast many-to-one traffic. If software needs an acknowledgment, it sends a separate unicast gather after the multicast completes.

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28 Systolic Support and Fabric Modes

28.1 Torus Wrap Links

IMPLEMENTED — per-dimension torus wrap is generated with `--torus=x,y,z`. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Each dimension can be wrapped independently with `--torus=x,y,z`. Periodic boundaries restore edge symmetry and halve diameter. The wrap links are folded so wire length doubles rather than growing with the dimension size. Deadlock freedom on wraps is handled by the dateline rule in §4.

28.2 Route Lookahead

The cell computes the next hop's output port one hop ahead of the flit's arrival. In steady state this collapses per-hop latency toward one cycle, which is the target for systolic repeat-cycle timing. The measured pipeline is 4 cycles/hop today (issue #120); the 1 cycle/hop target is deferred.

28.3 Source-Route Mode

For static systolic schedules, the injection shim can place an inline port list in the head-flit header. Intermediate cells forward without a table lookup, giving fixed-latency, table-free paths. Node-table routing remains the default for dynamic traffic. Source-route mode is generated with `--source-route`.

28.4 Speculative Allocation

The generator can enable speculative VC and switch allocation with `--speculation`. A head flit requests both a VC and a switch slot before the route is fully known, overlapping the allocators with the lookup. Mis-speculated grants are discarded and retried.

28.5 Standard Fabric Modes

A broadcast mode-switch (§3) selects one of 10 standard fabric modes. Every cell stores generator-emitted images for these modes. Mode 0 is custom (per-cell unicast tables).

28.5.1 Standard Fabric Modes

Standard fabric modes selected by broadcast mode-switch.

Mode	Name	Pattern
1	Mesh (default)	Generic packet switching using RAM tables; reset default is dimension-ordered routing.
2	Systolic-1D	Linear nearest-neighbor chains, row or column selected, optional torus ring; fixed source-route paths.
3	Wavefront-2D	2-D diagonal ripple with skewed E/W and N/S streams; per-diagonal static tables or source routes.
4	Stencil-3D	3-D halo/ghost-zone exchange with periodic boundaries; nearest-neighbor tables plus torus wrap on all dims.
5	Broadcast	One-to-all; multicast on VC0 with port masks to every cell.
6	Convergecast/reduce	All-to-one reduction tree; reverse-broadcast tables plus ocelus counter reduction.
7	All-to-all/transpose	Permutations such as transpose and shuffle/butterfly stages; per-stage table images.
8	Pipeline + rapids-stream	Boustrophedon serpentine chain; boundary cells stream to and from rapids DMA.
9	Tetrad all-to-all (K4)	Every 2×2×1 tetrad fully connected: perimeter via ±X/±Y,

Mode	Name	Pattern
		both diagonals via P_DIA; edge-adjacent and diagonal mates reach in one hop.
10	Tile all-to-all (K4 of tetrads)	The 4 tetrads of a tile fully connected: shared boundaries via ±X/±Y, diagonal tetrad pairs via P_DIA2; intra-tile dsts reach in 1..2 hops.

Mode images are data, not new hardware. Adding a mode means adding an image and a verification suite.

29 Observability and DFT

29.1 Ocelus Counter Suite

IMPLEMENTED — `delta_mesh_cell` exposes an eleven-entry 32-bit counter bank read through the config port. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

Each cell exposes saturating 32-bit counters readable through the config port. The suite is informed by NPU observability practice rather than by the sparse NoC literature. Counter indices 0..10 are defined; indices above 10 read back 0. The counter bank is selected by setting `table_index[15] = 1` on a config read.

Ocelus counter bank indices.

Index	Counter	Description
0	C_FLITS_IN	Flits received by the cell.
1	C_FLITS_OUT	Flits transmitted by the cell.
2	C_PKTS_IN	Packets received (TLAST handshakes).
3	C_PKTS_OUT	Packets transmitted (TLAST handshakes).
4	C_STALL_CYCLES	Cycles the cell saw output stall.
5	C_CREDIT_STALL	Cycles a granted output waited for downstream credit.
6	C_ERR_DROP	Malformed-destination drops (also mirrored on `o_err_drop_cnt`).
7	C_MODE_ACKS	Broadcast mode-switch acks received (also mirrored on `o_mode_acks`).
8	C_BULK_STARVE	Cycles bulk reservation was due.
9	C_SPEC_COMMITS	Speculative grants that committed.
10	C_SPEC_REVOKES	Speculative grants that were revoked.

Counters are frozen when `ENABLE_COUNTERS == 0`. They clear on `aresetn`.

29.2 DFT Test Mode

Test mode configures each cell into one of three deterministic routing patterns so the mesh wiring behaves as a concatenated bus. With three patterns, stuck-at and bridge faults are testable with approximately $\lceil \log_2(n) \rceil$ patterns. The mode is controlled through the config port using a DFT escape write (`table_index[15:12] = 4'hD`, payload bit 0 enables DFT, bits 2:1 select the pattern), and each cell drives an `o_dft_active` output.

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30 Performance and Verification

30.1 Performance Model

IMPLEMENTED — `bin/delta_mesh_perf.py` models the mesh and is calibrated by the regression suite. The design is per the delta mesh design spec dated 2026-10-13 (`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-13-delta-mesh-design.md`).

The `bin/delta_mesh_perf.py` model uses the standard interconnection-network cost model:

- **Zero-load latency** `T0 = H·tr + D/v + L/b`, where H is the hop count, tr is the per-hop router delay, D is the distance, v is the propagation speed, L is the packet length, and b is the channel bandwidth.
- **Queuing** is modeled as M/D/1 under deterministic flit service.
- **Saturation throughput** is derived from the maximum channel load γ_max, using bisection-bound and multicommodity-flow analysis. The model reports minimum delivered flow, not average.
- **Traffic patterns** include uniform random, nearest-neighbor/stencil, tornado, bit-complement, and transpose.
- **Methodology** uses infinite source queues, warm-up/measurement/drain phases, and latency measured from generation to departure.

Loaded-latency microbenchmarks follow NPU benchmarking practice. Network-calculus delay and backlog bounds for the fixed-priority classes are a phase-2 addition.

30.2 Verification Plan

The mesh verification plan is an 8-suite cocotb program. Each suite is a generator configuration plus a dedicated test file:

1. **Routing** — reset default DOR, programmed-table routing, table load via config port with readback verify.
2. **QoS** — strict priority order, aging inversion under saturation, bulk minimum reservation, class isolation under tree-saturation attack.
3. **Multicast** — fanout correctness, no-response rule, delivery-VC deadlock soak.
4. **Deadlock soak** — random traffic under adversarial-but-valid random tables, plus VC1 stress with VC0 escape, soaking to $N \times 10^6$ flits.
5. **Systolic** — torus nearest-neighbor ring/wavefront with measured per-hop latency, source-route fixed-latency path check, and 3-D stencil halo exchange.
6. **Counters** — every ocelus counter against a golden model.
7. **DFT mode** — three patterns route correctly; pattern count check.
8. **Perf model calibration** — measured versus modeled latency and throughput on the design-spec §10 patterns; report deltas.

Formal assists include an offline VC0-table acyclicity checker, one-hot grant assertions per output, and a TLAST-before-grant-release assertion that preserves packet atomicity. Detailed microarchitecture verification lives in the Delta MAS; the design spec dated 2026-10-13 is the source of truth for the architecture described here.

31 Deferred Items

STATUS — The mesh cell RTL is implemented. The items below remain deferred or are tracked in other workstreams.

The following features were considered and deferred:

- **CXS interface mode** — IMPLEMENTED (owner decision 2026-10-16): `--ifc {axis,cxs}` selects the interface plane; CXS mode wraps the unchanged AXIS core with native AMBA 5 CXS ports so a CXS rapids attaches without adapters. Validated for directed traffic; concurrent-load CXS shows a duplication/loss corner tracked as issue #122.
- **MonBus observation aggregation** — the tetrad/tile wrappers that merge cell MonBus streams live in the compute-eng-ip tile IP, not in delta (parallel session; datapath unchanged).
- **Route lookahead to 1 cycle/hop** — the aspirational systolic target; current measured pipeline is 4 cycles/hop (issue #120).
- **SRAM FIFO_IMPL** — the `--fifo-impl sram` option hangs in the current RTL (issue #118); regression uses `--fifo-impl reg`.
- **GT/TDM slot-table circuits** — Ethereal/NoC slot tables, headerless GT flits, end-to-end credit flow control, and optional VOQ. Phase-2 candidate.
- **Fault-tolerant routing** — block fault regions, software absorb/reinject, and fault-status registers.
- **Barrier/superstep sync wave** — ECLIPSE-style synchronization wave; lands with the CGRA work, not delta.
- **Express channels/cubes** — little use at the target radix; skipped.
- **Logical-to-physical address mapping** — revisit if remapping or fault-recovery demands it.
- **GALS/async links** — single clock is a deliberate simplification contrary to this literature direction.
- **VOQ option** — area/throughput trade; add when a user needs it.
- **Within-class per-flow fairness (WRR/DRR)** — deferred until a user asks.
- **Flit-reservation flow control** — revisit if systolic latency targets are not met by route lookahead.
- **Reliable-mode resend/NACK** — only if a control-plane user needs lossless delivery beyond class-0 VC isolation.